

DELHI The National Advisory Council (NAC), constituted by the Manmohan Singh Government a few days after it came to power in May 2004, seems slated to be buried once and for all. Ever since UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi resigned from NAC's top post on March 23, 2006, the chair has been lying vacant. And so have most of the seats since she quit. While during her tenure nearly all its members used to attend the council's meetings, in her absence, attendance shrunk to four—or sometimes even two—members.

On INDIA TODAY filing four appeals under the Right to Information Act (RTI) seeking to know whether the NAC still existed and was functioning, the council stated that "deliberations in the NAC were arranged and coordinated by Arun Bhatnagar, as secretary, NAC, in consultation with the

No Attendance Council



DISINTERESTED: Sonia

members of the council and assistance of the staff of NAC Secretariat".

Following the vacancy of the chairperson's post, "no member, NAC, chaired

the meetings".

The first appeal filed by INDIA TODAY under the RTI was on November 16, 2007, followed by three more appeals. The NAC

said that 25 meetings had been held after Sonia's resignation.

The council has nine members now as opposed to 12 members during Sonia's tenure. Interestingly, NAC had spent Rs 2.41 crore till January 3, 2008, since its constitution on June 3, 2004 to "monitor the implementation of the Common Minimum Programme". While it used to meet almost every month in the initial period, the frequency came down in subsequent months. Initially appointed for a period of one year, the council has been through several extensions, the latest of which expires on March 31.

Clearly, with Sonia not interested in its meetings or in appointing a head honcho to replace her and with elections looming round the corner, the council has lost its relevance.

by Shyam Lal Yadav

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Ram Vilas Paswan believes strongly in family values. So much so that he was easily dissuaded from cosying up to the NDA by Lalu Prasad Yadav who held out the bait of a Bihar Legislative Council seat to his son's father-in-law.

VOICES

“Pakistan is certainly not comfortable with the idea of India and particularly with India's democratic secular progress and economic growth.”

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition

“Those who say market growth is irrelevant and it only helps the rich are the worst enemies of the poor. They only want us to distribute poverty in this country.”

P. Chidambaram, finance minister

“Advani's autobiography, which is actually a hagiography, follows a simple principle—whatever good happened is attributable to him, whatever bad, to Vajpayee.”

Abhishek Singhvi, Congress spokesperson

“The democratic way would be to wait for the next elections. We do not presume the BJP is going to come to power.”

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary

“I like Tests. I belong to that generation. When the one-dayers started we said, ‘What is this nonsense?’”

Sharad Pawar, BCCI chief